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Personalized Promotions and Perceived Intrusiveness in Mobile Marketing

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ABSTRACT:

Smartphones have quietly reshaped the daily rhythm of modern life. People wake up to notifications, scroll through feeds during meals and close their eyes to the glow of a screen at night. Brands, fully aware of this shift, have responded by moving their promotional efforts to the very device that sits in every pocket. Among the various strategies mobile marketers use, personalisation crafting promotional messages around what a specific individual appears to want has become the dominant approach. It sounds, at first, like a sensible arrangement: the consumer gets relevant content, the brand gets better conversion rates. But something often goes wrong between intent and reception.

This study was designed to explore that gap. The central question is simple but layered: when mobile users encounter promotions that have clearly been built around their personal interests and behavior, do they feel helped or do they feel watched? The research gathered primary data from 133 participants through a structured Google Form survey distributed across WhatsApp, social media and peer networks. The survey covered four primary areas: who are the respondents, how they interact to promotional messages, how they feel about personalised ads and how they feel when those ads cross a line.

The data showed a significant difference within the same group of individuals. Around 63 to 71 percent of people who answered said that personalized ads were helpful, made shopping easier, and made them more likely to buy. At the same time, more than 54% said these ads bothered them, felt intrusive, and invaded their privacy. When asked to give an overall opinion, 59.4 percent said personalized ads were not helpful, and 52.3 percent said they did not want to get them again in the future. The numbers show that a consumer likes an ad that is relevant to them at the time, but they don't like how the ad was made.

The paper says that the main problem is not personalisation itself, but how it is used too much, with too little openness, and almost no user control. If brands are willing to rethink this strategy, they may find that customers are much more willing to work with them.

Keywords: Mobile marketing, Personalized promotions, Perceived intrusiveness, Consumer privacy, Digital advertising behavior

1. INTRODUCTION

1.1 How mobile became the primary advertising frontier

There was a time, not long ago, when a brand wanting to speak to a customer had limited options such as a television slot, a newspaper advertisement, a roadside hoarding. All of those channels was shared, not active, and not personal. The brands didn't know who was paying attention or what they really cared about, even though people watched, read, or walked by. That time is definitely over. Personalization has emerged as a prevailing strategy in digital marketing, confirmed by prior research on consumer engagement and targeted advertising (Agarwal & Karahanna, 2000).

Today, the mobile phone has given brands something they've never had before: a direct, personal, and always-on link to each customer. There are now more than 700 million smartphone users in India, and that number keeps going up. People don't just use their phones to talk to each other anymore. They shop, bank, learn, and have fun almost entirely through apps and mobile browsers. This has given marketers a place to send messages, keep track of them, improve them, and send them again all in the same afternoon.

There are now many different types of mobile marketing, such as push notifications from shopping apps, SMS messages with deals, WhatsApp broadcasts, sponsored posts on Instagram or Facebook, and display ads that are part of app content. These new types of advertising can all target a specific person based on data that has been collected, unlike older types of advertising. Most people haven't had time to think about how quickly the change from mass communication to personal communication has happened.

1.2 What personalisation means in this context

When a brand or platform personalises a promotional message, it means the content has been shaped at least in part by something the recipient has done, searched for, purchased, or otherwise signalled interest in. A person who recently looked at winter jackets on a shopping app may start seeing deals on jackets on several sites within hours. If someone has been watching cooking videos, they might get a notification about a new kitchen tool. The message isn't random; it's based on a picture of the person's interests.

The data infrastructure that powers almost every app on a modern smartphone makes this possible. Every time you tap, search, scroll, or buy something, algorithms use that information to build and improve a profile of you. The profile is then used to choose what promotional content to show, when to show it, and how to frame it. From a business point of view, it is a very effective system. From the customer's point of view, the experience is more complicated.

1.3 The problem this study addresses

Not every consumer greets a personalised promotion with enthusiasm. A growing number of mobile users have begun to notice and in many cases object to the degree to which their behaviour is being monitored and used to target them. The feeling that an app or brand 'knows too much' about a person's habits and preferences can produce a reaction that is quite different from gratitude. It can produce discomfort, suspicion and a sense that something private has been read without permission.

1.4 Why this research matters now

The timing of this study is relevant. Digital marketing regulations, data privacy conversations and consumer awareness of surveillance-based advertising have all intensified globally in recent years. In India, debates around data protection legislation and user rights are ongoing. Against this backdrop, understanding where ordinary consumers stand what they tolerate, what they value and what makes them want to disengage carries practical significance for marketers, platform designers, regulators and researchers alike.

A business that understands its customers' boundaries will ultimately build stronger relationships than one that simply maximises short-term reach. This research is motivated by that belief.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 The case that scholars have made for personalised advertising

Academic work on personalised advertising has been accumulating since the late 1990s and the general weight of that work has been favourable toward personalisation as a marketing strategy. Researchers who looked into early-stage e-commerce found that product recommendation engines significantly increased both the amount of time people spent browsing and the number of transactions that were completed. The easy-to-understand explanation they gave was based on what scientists call fluency: when a message or suggestion fits with what someone is already thinking, the brain processes it more easily, and that ease of processing makes the person feel better about the source. Personalized advertising has been shown to increase user engagement and make the shopping experience better by giving people content that is relevant to them (Agarwal & Karahanna, 2000).

As mobile commerce evolved during the 2000s and 2010s, researchers adapted these findings to the smartphone context. Research on Indian and Southeast Asian markets showed that younger consumers, especially those in urban areas with greater smartphone knowledge, were more open and responsive to personalized mobile promotions compared to their older or rural consumers. This group was more likely to see a well-targeted ad as a time-saving convenience than as an annoyance. They had also grown up with algorithmic recommendations on sites like YouTube and Instagram, so personally curated content didn't

seem scary to them. People are more likely to respond positively to ads that are in line with their interests and preferences (Baek & Morimoto, 2012).

In this literature, several conditions consistently emerged as requirements for the acceptance of personalization rather than its resistance. The customer needs to feel that the suggestion fits with what they have already shown they like. The channel needs to feel like a good fit. A recommendation on a shopping app feels more natural than getting the same recommendation as an unsolicited SMS. Also, the timing is important. An ad that shows up while someone is actively browsing is much less annoying than one that shows up while they are doing something else. Recent research supports that personalized advertising enhances consumer engagement and purchase intention in mobile contexts (Kumar et al., 2021)

2.2 Privacy concern and why consumers pull back

Running parallel to the personalisation literature is a robust body of research on why consumers resist data-driven marketing. In this academic tradition, privacy concern means how someone feels about the risk or discomfort of having their personal information collected and used. It's not about whether the law has really broken privacy. It's about how the person feels about being exposed. Privacy concerns significantly affect consumer attitudes toward digital marketing and data sharing (Malhotra et al., 2004).

Researchers have identified various factors that consistently rise privacy concerns in digital environments. The most powerful factor is the feeling that they have no control: when people think they can't stop the data collection, see what is being kept, or fix or delete it, they become very uncomfortable. Another important aspect is the invisibility of data collection: most users have no idea what a given app records about them, and that ignorance tends to create anxiety rather than comfort. A third factor is contextual integrity, a concept that captures the intuition that information shared in one context (say, a search for medical symptoms) feels violated when it appears in a completely different context (a targeted pharmaceutical ad). Consumers are often uncomfortable with their personal data being tracked and used without clear understanding and control (Chellappa & Sin, 2005).

What is particularly instructive in this literature for the present study is the finding that privacy concern does not always lead to avoidance. In many documented cases, consumers continue to use apps and services they know to be data-hungry, in part because they can't see a realistic alternative and in part because the immediate benefits feel more real than the abstract risk of data misuse. This tension between attitude and behaviour is relevant to the interpretation of the data in the following sections. In recent years, issues of data privacy and transparency have become increasingly important in digital marketing (Martin et al., 2022; Tucker, 2020)

2.3 Intrusiveness as a distinct consumer experience

The concept of intrusiveness as studied in advertising research draws a distinction between an ad being unwanted (which is almost universally true) and an ad being intrusive (which happens when the unwanted content actively disrupts something the consumer was doing or thinking). Early intrusiveness research focused on television commercials and found that viewers experienced intrusiveness most acutely when an ad broke into a particularly engaging programme and when the ad content was irrelevant to the viewer's interests.

When the concept moved into digital advertising research, it acquired additional complexity. A pop-up ad that forces interaction is intrusive in the disruptive sense. But a targeted ad that knows exactly which product a user was comparing prices on two days ago can be intrusive in a different, arguably more unsettling sense the sense that one's private cognitive life has been accessed. Both forms of intrusiveness lead to negative advertising outcomes, but through different psychological routes. Disruptive intrusiveness triggers irritation; surveillance-like intrusiveness triggers unease or distrust.

Mobile marketing sits at the intersection of both. Push notifications are disruptive by design they interrupt whatever the user is doing. And the personalised content within those notifications activates the surveillance-type intrusiveness if the targeting is visible enough to feel uncanny. Researchers have documented this combined effect producing higher rates of notification disabling, app uninstallation and brand unfavorability than less targeted forms of mobile advertising. Perceived intrusiveness of advertisements leads to irritation and negative consumer responses (Edwards et al., 2002). Recent research shows that perceived intrusiveness in mobile advertising negatively affects user trust and leads to ad avoidance behaviour (Li & Kannan, 2022).

2.4 What the existing research does not cover

Despite the depth of work in each of these three areas personalisation effectiveness, privacy concern and intrusiveness there remains a meaningful gap. Very few studies have brought all three together within a primary-data research design that looks at Indian mobile consumers specifically and that treats the contradictions within the same sample as a feature rather than a problem to be explained away. The personalization–privacy paradox explains how consumers simultaneously appreciate relevant ads while being concerned about privacy (Xu et al., 2011). This personalization–privacy paradox continues to be widely observed in recent studies (Aguirre et al., 2021).

Most of the published research on this topic either takes a pro-personalisation stance and focuses on effectiveness metrics, or takes a consumer protection stance and focuses on privacy violation. What is rarer is a study that sits with the paradox — that acknowledges both the genuine value consumers find in relevant

promotions and their simultaneous resistance to the experience of being targeted. This study attempts to occupy that middle ground. Consumer acceptance of mobile advertising depends on perceived usefulness and level of trust in the platform (Merisavo et al., 2007).

3. METHODOLOGY

The methodology for this study is designed to capture and quantify subjective perceptions of diversity and equity through a structured, replicable framework.

3.1 Overall research approach

This study is built on a descriptive and quantitative research framework. This approach is widely used in consumer behaviour research to analyse perceptions and attitudes (Malhotra et al., 2004). The choice of a descriptive approach reflects the nature of the research question: the goal is not to test whether personalisation causes intrusiveness in a controlled experimental sense, but to describe the range and distribution of consumer attitudes as they actually exist in a real-world sample. Quantitative methods were chosen because they allow responses to be counted, percentages to be calculated and patterns to be identified across a reasonably sized group.

3.2 How the survey was built and distributed

The primary data collection tool was a structured questionnaire hosted on Google Forms. The questionnaire was divided into five sections. The first section gathered demographic information age, gender, occupation and daily phone usage time. The second part asked how often people got mobile ads and which platforms they got them on. The third part used a five-point scale to ask about people's feelings about personalized promotions. The fourth part asked about how intrusive people felt using the same scale. The fifth part asked for general opinions on personalized promotions and what people would like to see in the future.

The form was distributed primarily through WhatsApp group messages, Instagram and direct sharing within friends, family and network. There was no money involved, and everyone who wanted to could join. Respondents could complete the survey at any time over the two-week collection window.

3.3 Sample size and who responded

A total of 133 valid responses were collected. Some items had slightly fewer responses (between 128 and 132) because a few people skipped questions that weren't required. The sample consists of individuals from three separate occupational categories: students, employed individuals, and those currently unemployed, including age groups ranging from 18 to over 46. The number of male and female respondents was almost the same.

Convenience sampling was used which is a practical and well accepted method in undergraduate and post graduate academic research. That said, it does mean that the findings are most directly applicable to the type of accessible, digitally connected population that could be reached through the distribution channels used, rather than the general population of India. This limitation is acknowledged clearly.

3.4 Variables in the study

The study treats personalised promotions as the independent variable the stimulus that respondents are reacting to. Perceived intrusiveness is the dependent variable the response or outcome being measured. Demographic characteristics including age, gender, occupation and smartphone usage time serve as contextual variables that help interpret how attitudes vary across different types of respondents.

3.5 The Likert scale and what the numbers mean

Sections 3 and 4 of the survey used a five-point Likert scale where 1 meant Strongly Agree and 5 meant Strongly Disagree. This means that in the resulting data, a high percentage of Scale 1 responses indicates strong agreement with the statement. Lower-numbered responses reflect more positive or stronger agreement and higher numbers indicate disagreement or distance from the statement. This convention is maintained consistently throughout the analysis sections below.

3.6 Statistical tools and techniques used

The collected data was analyzed using appropriate statistical tools to ensure accurate interpretation of respondents' perceptions. The primary tools used in this study include:

- **Percentage analysis:** This method was used to convert raw data into percentages, making it easier to interpret and compare responses across different categories.
- **Frequency distribution:** Frequency tables were prepared to understand how often each response option was selected by respondents.
- **Microsoft excel:** MS Excel was used as the main tool for data tabulation, calculation and graphical representation. It helped in organizing large datasets efficiently and generating charts such as bar graphs and pie charts.
- **Likert scale analysis:** A five-point Likert scale was used to measure respondents' attitudes, where:
1 = Strongly Agree
2 = Agree
3 = Neutral
4 = Disagree

5 = Strongly Disagree

This helped in quantifying subjective opinions into measurable data.

These tools allowed to identify patterns, trends and relationships within the data effectively.

3.7 Questionnaire

The following structured questionnaire was used to collect primary data through Google form:

Section A: Demographic information

1. What is your age group?

18–25

26–35

36–45

46 and above

2. What is your gender?

Male

Female

3. What is your occupation?

Student

Employed

Not working

4. How many hours do you use your smartphone daily?

Less than 2 hours

2–4 hours

4–6 hours

More than 6 hours

Section B: Exposure to mobile promotions

1. How often do you receive promotional messages on your mobile?

Daily

Weekly

Occasionally

Rarely

2. Through which platform do you mostly receive promotional messages?

Shopping apps (Amazon, Flipkart)

WhatsApp

SMS

Social media

Email

3. Do you usually open promotional messages?

Yes

No

Section C: Attitudes toward personalised promotions

(Use Likert Scale: 1 = Strongly Agree, 5 = Strongly Disagree)

1. Personalised promotions improve my shopping experience

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

2. Personalised ads are useful to me

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

3. I prefer personalised ads over general ads

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

4. Personalised promotions match my interests

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

5. Personalised ads increase my purchase intention

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Section D: Perceived intrusiveness

(Likert Scale: 1 = Strongly Agree, 5 = Strongly Disagree)

1. Too many promotional messages are annoying

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

2. Personalised ads invade my privacy

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

3. I feel uncomfortable when my behavior is tracked

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

4. Promotional messages disturb my daily activities

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

5. Personalised promotions feel intrusive

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

Section E: Overall opinion

1. Do you think personalised promotions are beneficial overall?

Yes

No

Maybe

2. Would you like to receive personalised promotions in the future?

Yes

No

Maybe

3. What type of promotional communication do you prefer?

No promotional messages

Only important updates

Occasional relevant ads

Regular promotional messages

4. DATA ANALYSIS AND FINDINGS

4.1 Analytical approach

The data gathered through the structured Google Forms survey was analysed using descriptive statistical methods, specifically frequency distribution and percentage analysis. Microsoft Excel was used for all data tabulation and calculation, allowing for systematic organisation of responses across each survey item. This approach suited the descriptive nature of the study, where the primary objective was to identify patterns and dominant trends across 133 respondents rather than establish causal relationships. Results are presented

through tables supported by interpretive commentary to ensure the findings are both accessible and analytically meaningful.

4.2 Statistical analysis of data

The data collected from 133 respondents was analyzed using descriptive statistical techniques. Percentage analysis revealed that the majority of respondents fall within the age group of 18–25 years (39.1%), indicating a young and digitally active sample.

Frequency distribution analysis showed that 48.1% of respondents receive promotional messages weekly, while 17.3% receive them daily, highlighting high exposure to mobile marketing.

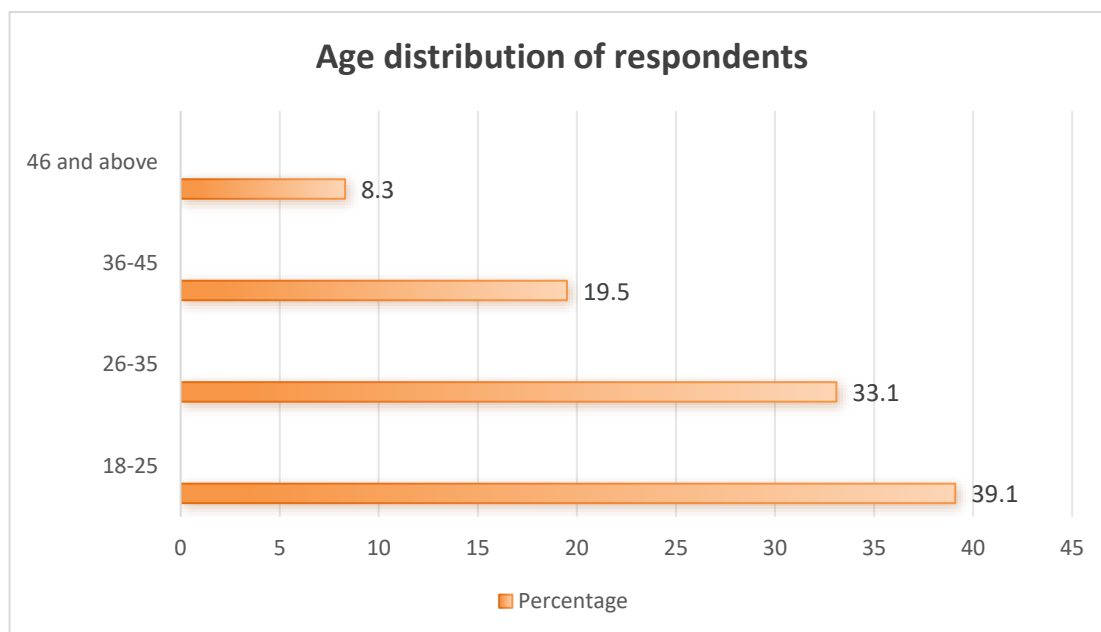
Likert scale analysis indicated strong agreement with statements related to the usefulness of personalised promotions, with 71.4% agreeing that such ads improve their shopping experience. However, the same analysis revealed that 60.2% of respondents strongly agreed that excessive promotional messages are annoying and 54.1% felt that such ads invade their privacy.

Graphical tools such as bar charts and pie charts were used to visually represent these findings, making it easier to identify trends and compare responses.

4.3 Demographic profile of respondents

Table 1: Age distribution of survey respondents

Age group	No. of respondents	Percentage (%)
18-25	52	39.1
26-35	44	33.1
36-45	26	19.5
46 and above	11	8.3
Total	133	100.0

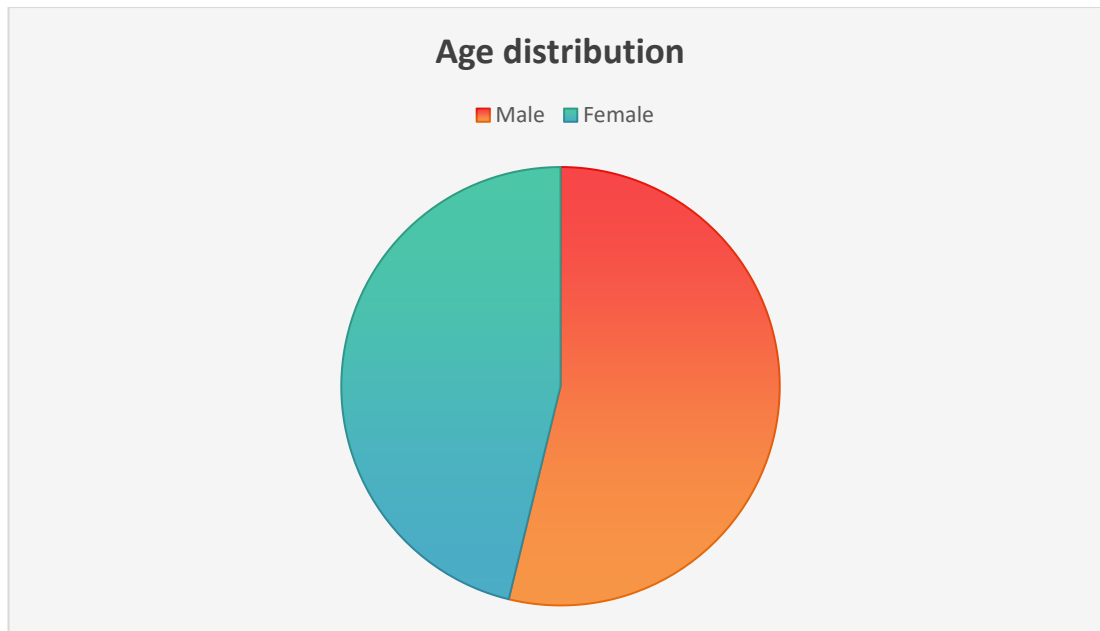


The sample reflected a fairly diverse cross-section of digitally active individuals. Age-wise, the largest group fell between 18 and 25 years, accounting for 39.1% of respondents, followed by the 26–35 bracket at 33.1%. Together, these two groups represented nearly three-quarters of the total sample a composition that is consistent with the distribution channels used, primarily WhatsApp and social media, which skew toward younger users. Respondents aged 36–45 made up 19.5%, while those above 46 contributed the remaining 8.3%.

Table 2: Gender of respondents

Gender	No. of respondents	Percentage (%)
Male	70	53.8
Female	60	46.2
Total	130	100.0

Gender distribution was notably balanced, with 53.8% male and 46.2% female respondents among the 130 who answered this item. Occupationally, the sample was almost evenly divided: students (33.3%), employed individuals (34.1%) and those not currently working (32.6%). This balance is analytically useful since purchasing behaviour and sensitivity toward advertising tend to vary with financial circumstances and daily routines.

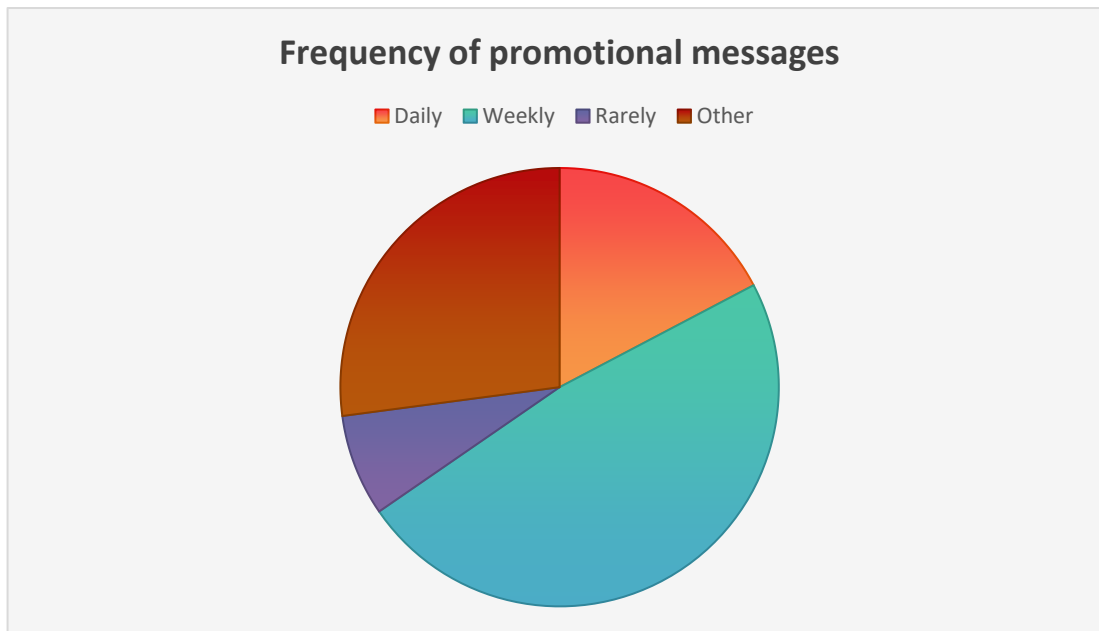


Regarding smartphone usage, nearly 70% of respondents reported using their phones for two or more hours daily. About 17.3% used their devices for over six hours. This level of engagement confirms that the sample was not peripherally exposed to mobile marketing they were deeply embedded in the digital environments where such promotions appear regularly.

4.4 Exposure to mobile promotions

Frequency distribution of promotional exposure revealed that 48.1% of respondents received promotional messages a few times each week, while 17.3% received them daily. Combined, over 65% of the sample experienced regular promotional contact through their mobile devices. Only 7.5% said they rarely received such messages, which suggests that mobile marketing saturation is a lived reality for this group rather than a hypothetical concern.

This pattern suggests that mobile platforms have become a dominant medium for marketers to reach consumers efficiently and repeatedly. The widespread exposure also implies that users are continuously engaged within digital ecosystems where promotional content is embedded into their routine activities. Conversely, only a small percentage of respondents, approximately 7.5%, indicated that they rarely receive promotional messages, showing that minimal exposure is relatively uncommon.

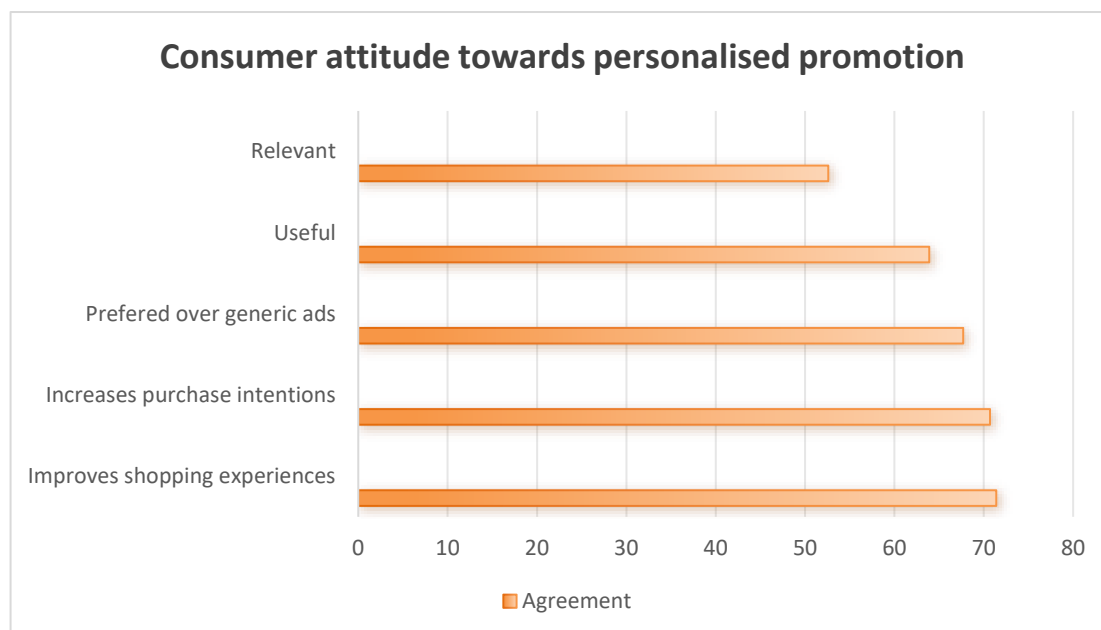


In terms of platform, mobile shopping applications such as Flipkart and Amazon were the most common channel, cited by 30.1% of respondents. WhatsApp followed at 21.8%, a finding worth noting given that this platform is primarily associated with personal communication. SMS and social media were close behind at 19.5% and 18.8% respectively, while email remained the least prominent at 9.8%. The prevalence of promotions across personal communication channels particularly WhatsApp likely contributes to the sense of intrusion many respondents later reported.

Despite this volume, 54.1% of respondents said they do open promotional messages when they receive them, while 45.9% do not. The slight majority who engage with these messages suggests that relevance does draw at least some attention, even among those who express discomfort with the practice overall.

4.5 Attitudes toward personalised promotions

Responses to the five Likert-scale statements on personalisation attitudes were largely favourable. Using a scale where 1 indicated Strong Agreement and 5 indicated Strong Disagreement, a majority of respondents selected Scale 1 across all five items. The statement "My shopping experience is better because of personalised promotions" drew the highest agreement at 71.4%, followed closely by purchase intention at 70.7% and preference for personalised over generic ads at 67.7%. Perceived usefulness registered at 63.9%, while relevance the feeling that received promotions actually match one's interests was affirmed by 52.6%.

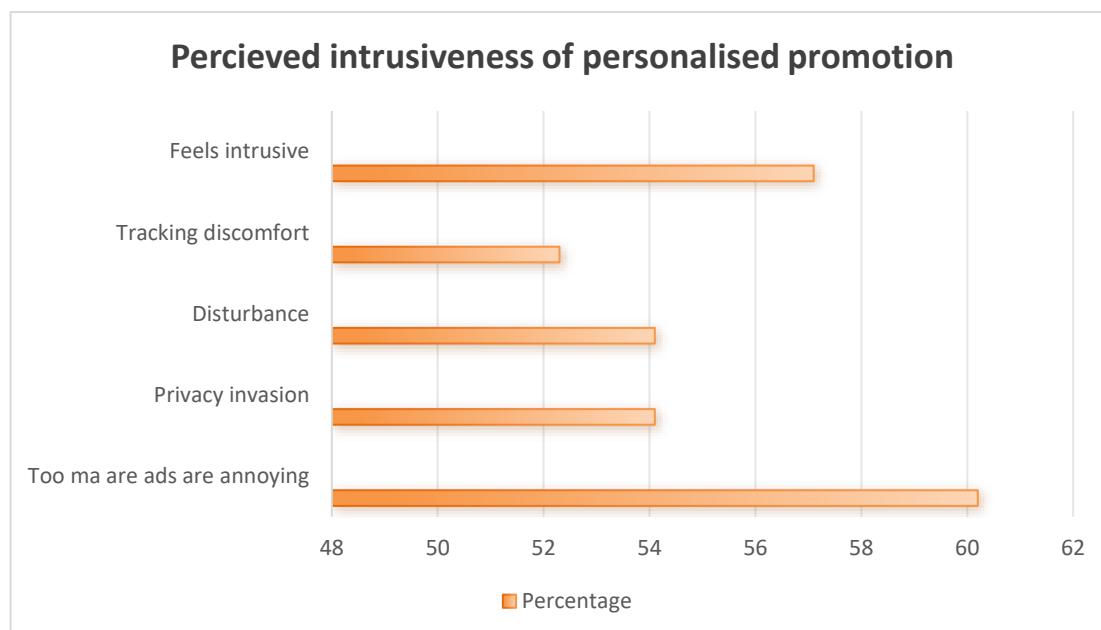


These figures indicate that the sample, on the whole, has had tangible positive experiences with personalised advertising. They have encountered promotions that felt timely, discovered products through targeted suggestions and found the experience preferable to random advertising. These are not negligible proportions they represent clear majorities in every case.

4.6 Perceived intrusiveness

Where the data grows more complicated is in the intrusiveness section. Using the same Likert scale, respondents expressed equally strong and, in some cases, stronger agreement with statements describing discomfort, annoyance and privacy concern. The statement receiving the highest Strongly Agree response was "Too many promotional messages are annoying," at 60.2%. This was the single highest Scale 1 figure in the entire intrusiveness section, pointing to message frequency as the most pressing source of consumer frustration.

Privacy invasion was strongly acknowledged by 54.1% of respondents, an identical figure to those who said frequent messages disturb them. Discomfort with behavioural tracking stood at 52.3% and 57.1% Strongly Agreed that personalised promotions sometimes feel genuinely intrusive. These are majority positions and they sit within the same respondent pool that earlier expressed appreciation for relevant ads.

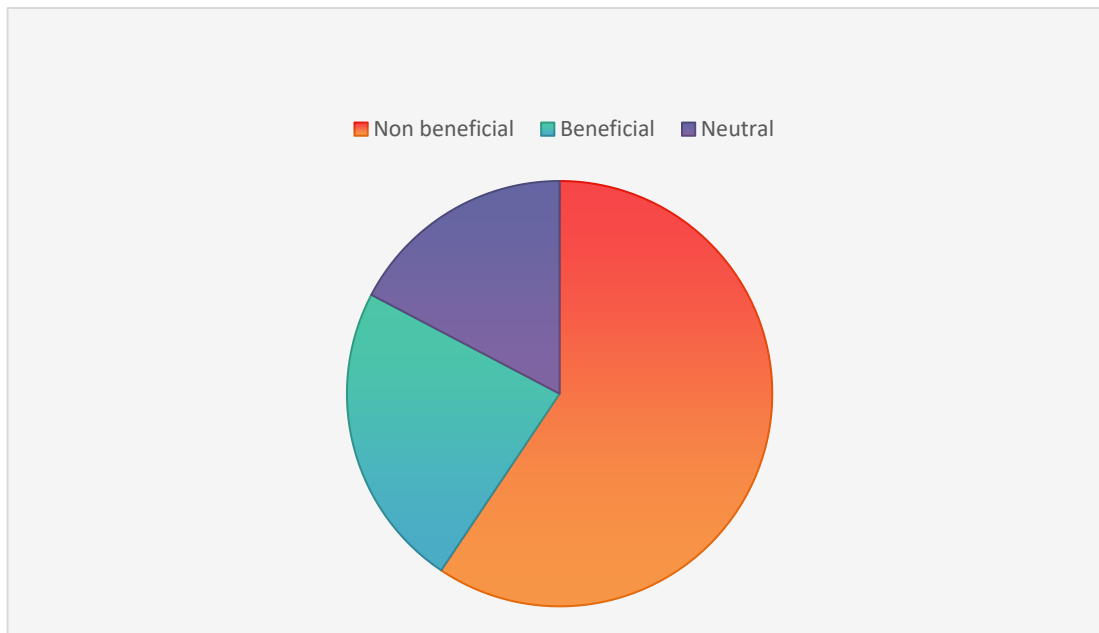


4.7 Overall findings and interpretation

The most revealing data emerged in the final section. Despite expressing situational appreciation for personalised promotions, 32.3% of respondents concluded that such promotions were not beneficial overall. Only 25.5% gave an affirmative overall judgment. When asked about future preferences, 45.2% said they would prefer not to receive personalised promotions, while only 33.3% actively wanted to continue receiving them. A notable 42.2% expressed conditional openness willing to engage, but only under circumstances that currently do not exist in most mobile marketing practice.

Preferred communication style reinforced this pattern: 28.9% wanted no promotional messages at all and 27.3% preferred contact only for important updates. Together, these two groups represent over half the sample

What the data collectively describes is a consumer who can recognise value in personalised advertising at the level of individual interactions, but who has grown resistant to the system that produces those interactions largely due to excessive frequency, limited transparency and a persistent feeling of being monitored without meaningful consent. The contradiction is not a data anomaly; it is an accurate reflection of how people navigate a technology they find both useful and unsettling.



5. DISCUSSION

5.1 Making sense of the contradiction

The data from this study does not fit neatly into any single story about personalised mobile marketing. It is not a story of consumers who love being targeted and respond enthusiastically to every relevant promotion. Nor is it a story of consumers who are uniformly resistant to advertising on their phones and want to be left alone entirely. It is something messier and more honest than either of those: a story of people who recognise value in certain moments while resenting the overall system that delivers those moments.

This tension between momentary appreciation and cumulative resentment is what makes the personalisation paradox so important to understand. A brand looking only at engagement metrics might conclude from open rates and click-throughs that its personalised campaigns are working. What those metrics will not capture is the growing irritation, the background noise of feeling watched, the slow erosion of trust that builds up over weeks and months of being targeted. The survey captures that erosion in a way that behavioural data cannot. This tension between momentary appreciation and cumulative resentment reflects the personalization–privacy paradox identified in earlier research (Xu et al., 2011).

5.2 Volume is the loudest problem

Among all the specific things respondents found troubling about personalised promotions, the frequency of messaging generated the strongest and most consistent negative response. Sixty percent of respondents Strongly Agreed that too many promotional messages are annoying the highest Strongly Agree figure in the entire intrusiveness section. This tells brands something straightforward: the issue is not just what you are sending, it is how often you are sending it.

There is a point at which even a relevant, well-timed message stops feeling like a service and starts feeling like harassment. Most brands appear to be operating past that threshold for most of their customers, if this sample is any guide. The fix does not require dismantling personalisation as a strategy. It requires discipline around communication frequency caps on how often a user can be contacted within a given period, smarter logic for determining when to send and when to hold back and genuine responsiveness when a user signals, they want fewer messages. This aligns with earlier findings on advertising intrusiveness, where excessive exposure leads to irritation and negative consumer attitudes (Edwards et al., 2002).

5.3 The privacy problem is structural not cosmetic

The discomfort respondents expressed about behavioural tracking and privacy invasion is harder to address with simple operational changes. More than half the sample 54.1 percent strongly agreed that personalised ads invade their privacy and 52.3 percent strongly agreed they are uncomfortable when apps track their behaviour. These are majority views and they speak to something structural about how personalised marketing currently works. These findings are consistent with prior studies highlighting consumer concerns about lack of control over personal data and privacy risks (Malhotra et al., 2004).

The problem is that most consumers have little genuine understanding of what data is being collected about them, by whom, for how long and for what purposes. When a promotional message appears that clearly reflects private browsing or purchase behaviour, the consumer's reaction is often to feel that something has been taken from them without their knowledge. Even if the data collection was technically disclosed in a terms and conditions document that nobody reads, the experience of it is not one of informed consent. It is the experience of surveillance.

Addressing this at a meaningful level would require brands and platforms to communicate with users in plain, honest language about what they know and why they are using it. It would require giving users real control not a toggle buried in settings but a visible, accessible way to shape what they receive and why. Currently, few brands do this well and the data from this survey suggests that the cost of that failure is paid in consumer trust. This supports earlier research suggesting that consumers feel discomfort when their personal information is used without clear awareness or consent (Chellappa & Sin, 2005). Recent studies highlight that transparency and user control are essential for building trust in digital marketing environments (Martin et al., 2022).

5.4 What the 'maybe' group tells us

One finding worth dwelling on is the significant proportion of respondent's 33.3 percent who said they might want to receive personalised promotions in the future under certain conditions. This group is neither

firmly opposed nor enthusiastically in favour. They represent a space of conditional openness that brands have not yet earned the right to enter.

What conditions would bring this group onside? The preference data gives some clues: relevance only messaging that actually connects to their interests; rarity not constant contact but occasional, well-chosen moments; and implied in both of those, trust. Trust that the brand has understood what they actually want rather than simply what the algorithm predicts. Trust that their data is not being shared or misused. Trust that they can easily say stop if they change their mind.

That is a high bar. But it is the bar that a substantial minority of mobile consumers have set. Brands that choose to meet it rather than work around it will likely find a qualitatively different kind of customer relationship on the other side. This behaviour aligns with studies indicating that consumers remain conditionally open to personalised marketing when transparency and trust are ensured (Dinev & Hart, 2006).

6. CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The study concludes that the organization is currently at a "performative" stage of DEI development. To transition toward a truly equitable culture, the institution must shift its focus from general diversity statements to equity-based accountability.

This study began with a straightforward question: how do mobile users in India respond to personalised promotional messages? The answer that emerged from 133 survey respondents is neither straightforward nor comfortable for mobile marketers to hear.

Consumers do find personalised ads useful to some extent. A majority found shopping experiences improved, purchase motivation was increased, and a preference for relevant content over generic noise was expressed. These are real benefits and not to be sneezed at. In a marketing context the principle of personalisation has real value.

But at the same time, the majority said they feel disturbed by frequent messages, uncomfortable being tracked and violated in their sense of privacy. And when asked to make a general judgment about whether personalised promotions were a good thing, almost 60 per cent said no. More than half said they would rather not get such promotions in the future.

The conclusion this study draws from that combination of findings is not that personalisation should be abandoned. It is that the personalization in mobile marketing as it is practiced today has fundamentally failed to earn consumer trust and that without trust the real benefits of relevance are outweighed by the accumulated cost of feeling constantly monitored.

The data points to three specific, necessary minimum steps: cut back on communication frequency so messages feel like events, not wallpaper; be transparent with consumers about what data is powering the promotions they see; and give people real, easy control over their preferences. None of these is technically difficult. All they need is a real willingness to treat consumers as participants, not targets.

For Kalinga University students and early-career professionals studying marketing: Consumers you will serve in your careers are already worn out with the volume and lack of transparency of digital advertising. The marketers who can build strategies based on honesty, relevance and respect will have a significant advantage over those who optimize for reach.

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